Get Mom's Care Routine Out of One Person's Head

Four short exercises to write down what the coordinator knows, agree what every update includes, pick where the plan lives, and see what a backup would be missing.

Where you are

Your brother coordinates most of what Mom needs, and he does it well. He also does it from memory. Nothing urgent is happening, but if he were out of reach for a week, nobody else would know where to start. You have time to change that.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can say what information a backup would need, what a standard update should contain, and where the current plan will be kept so anyone with permission can find it.

A one-page readiness sheet: What the Coordinator Knows, Our Update Format, Where the Current Plan Lives, and What a Backup Would Still Be Missing.

Before you start

- A conversation with the coordinator, or their rough notes on what they do.
- A sample of how the family currently shares updates, like a group text thread.
- Any paper or files that already exist, like a medication list or contact sheet. Whatever you have on hand is enough for today.

PROMPT 1

Write down what the coordinator carries in their head

WHY THIS MATTERS

The coordinator knows the pharmacy's hours, which neighbor has a key, and that Mom won't take pills from a stranger. None of that is written anywhere. Getting it onto paper is the first step, and the coordinator is the only one who can do it.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Fifteen minutes with the coordinator and a few questions, or their own notes.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My brother coordinates my mother's care mostly from memory, and we want to write it down while things are calm. Here is what he told me when I asked him to walk me through a normal week:

> [PASTE HIS NOTES OR YOUR NOTES FROM THE CONVERSATION]
>
> Organize it under these headings: PEOPLE AND HOW TO REACH THEM, THE WEEKLY ROUTINE, THINGS ONLY HE KNOWS (habits, preferences, workarounds), WHERE THINGS ARE KEPT (papers, keys, accounts, described but not the details), and OPEN QUESTIONS. Then list ten questions a backup would probably ask that these notes don't answer. Don't fill in any answers he didn't give.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The 'only he knows' section. That's what disappears if he's unreachable.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Hand the ten questions back to the coordinator and ask him to answer the ones he can.

PROMPT 2

Decide what every update should include

WHY THIS MATTERS

If each update has the same shape, a backup can read the last few and catch up. If each one is a free-form text, they have to read everything and still guess.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A handful of recent updates about Mom, from a group text or email, with names removed.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are some recent updates my family has shared about my mother's care:
>
> [PASTE FIVE TO TEN RECENT MESSAGES, NAMES REMOVED]
>
> Look at what they contain and what they leave out. Then propose a standard update format with no more than six labeled parts, such as what changed, what's needed, who's handling it, by when, and who should confirm. For each part, say briefly why it matters for someone catching up later. Then rewrite two of my sample messages in the new format so I can see the difference. Keep the tone the way my family actually talks.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A format short enough that people will use it on a phone.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Show the two rewritten messages to the family and ask whether they'd actually write this way.

PROMPT 3

Pick where the current plan will live, and who can get to it

WHY THIS MATTERS

A plan that's in three email threads and a drawer is not a shared plan. The question isn't which app. It's whether the backup could find the current version at eleven at night without calling anyone.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A list of where Mom's information is right now: papers, phones, email, apps, people's memories.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is where information about my mother's care currently lives:
>
> [LIST THE PLACES: PAPER FILES, PHONES, EMAIL, APPS, PEOPLE'S MEMORIES]
>
> Make a table with columns: INFORMATION, WHERE IT IS NOW, WHO CAN GET TO IT TODAY, and WOULD A BACKUP FIND IT WITHOUT ASKING (yes, no, or unsure). Then list the questions my family would need to settle before choosing one place for the current plan: who needs access, what must stay private, how we'd mark which version is current, and what happens if the usual coordinator can't update it. Don't recommend a specific app or service. Describe what a good location would need to do.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How many rows say 'no' in the last column.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Bring the questions to the family. The choice of place is theirs, not the AI's.

PROMPT 4

See what a backup would still be missing

WHY THIS MATTERS

You won't know what's missing until you imagine someone stepping in. You don't need to stage a real absence to do that on paper. The real rehearsal comes later.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what we've written down so far about how my mother's care is coordinated:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Imagine the coordinator is unreachable for one week starting tomorrow and a family member has to step in using only what's written here. Produce a one-page readiness sheet with four headings: WHAT THE COORDINATOR KNOWS (summarized), OUR UPDATE FORMAT (blank, ready to copy), WHERE THE CURRENT PLAN LIVES (what we've decided, or 'not yet decided'), and WHAT A BACKUP WOULD STILL BE MISSING. Under the last heading, list each gap as a question and mark whether it's information, access, or a decision nobody has made. Don't name who the backup should be.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The gaps marked 'access.' Information you can write down tonight; access takes arranging.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Fix one access gap this month, and bring the sheet to the step below.

Start the shared record now, while it's calm

A backup needs the same picture of Mom that the coordinator carries around. The care interview captures that picture area by area into a Family Care Profile, a natural home for the current plan.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›